CHAPTER 17

T R A N S P O R T, T R A D E A N D S E R V I C E S

The group of activities comprehended in Transport, Trade and Services is very important in the economy of Palestine. It accounted for about one-fifth of the total gainfully occupied in the past decade. In the Jewish economy alone these activities were even more important. About 34 percent of the Jewish labor force was engaged in these activities in 1939 and as much as ~~50~~ 37 percent in 1942; these are larger shares than were engaged in either manufacturing or agriculture.

TRANSPORT

Shipping

Transport by sea has been very important to Palestine because of the large role of international trade in her economic life, particularly in the Jewish sector. Shipping was also necessary to handle the offtake of the Iraq oil pipeline at its Haifa terminus. Moreover, as Palestine became able to take advantage of its central location, the Palestinian ports partially replaced Alexandria and Beirut in supplying Syria, Iraq and Iran. While the tonnage of dry cargo handled in Palestine ports rose from 492,000 in 1930 to an average of 1,399,000 in 1935-39, in all Syrian ports the tonnage rose only from 688,000 to 728,000. Even at its prewar peak, however, Palestine handled only about 60 percent as much cargo as Alexandria.

Officially Palestine has five ports. Two, Acre and Gaza, have only local significance and are served chiefly by sailing vessels engaged in coastwise traffic. Jaffa port, dating from Biblical times, and Tel Aviv, constructed during the disturbances of 1936-39, are no more than lighterage basins serving ships that must anchor two to three kilometers offshore in the open roadstead. The fifth port, Haifa, is a protected, deep-sea harbor constructed in a natural bay. Once there was a firm decision to bring the Mosul oil by pipeline to Haifa, the Government decided to build a modern